fall one day, ‘just like the useless and ridiculous walls of fortified cities of earlier times have fallen’.10 Honecker, who had last seen Paris in 1935, toured the royal palace at Versailles, dined in the Eiffel Tower and attended a performance by famed mime artist Marcel Marceau.

However, on his return to Berlin, he could not settle. That winter, he held other enthusiastic encounters with Western politicians, including FDP federal chairman Otto Graf Lambsdorff and the governing mayor of West Berlin, Eberhard Diepgen, who managed to secure overnight stays for West Berliners visiting the East on day trips. Soon after, the red carpet was rolled out for Rhineland-Palatinate Minister-President Bernhard Vogel in East Berlin.

For these visiting dignitaries, it was quite clear the GDR was still not jumping on Gorbachev’s revolutionary train which was beginning to derail regimes across the Soviet bloc. On 19 February, news arrived that more than 100,000 demonstrators in Lithuania rolled out loudspeakers to demand political change and independence. A week later, on 24 February, 3,000 people in the Soviet Republic of Estonia defied a ban to rally in support of independence. Officials were greeted with shouts of ‘Freedom now!’ By 25 March, demonstrations had spread to Czechoslovakia where Roman Catholic groups marked the first mass protest against the socialist government since the sixties. Even more concerning, news arrived from Hungary; where Honecker’s long-time friend Janos Kadar was cast into political oblivion after attempting to censure reformists.

As problems in the socialist world intensified, ARD, ZDF and West German satellite channels devoted more airtime to the unrest. The ‘negative occurrences’ taking place in Hungary, Czechoslovakia and elsewhere ‘immediately enter the German Democratic Republic via Western TV,’ Honecker fumed. When speaking with Vadim Medvedev, a Gorbachev aide and ideologist, he asserted the West was ‘not happy with the calm in the GDR. We must tackle the problem ideologically.’11 Meanwhile, new hostile voices began beaming in from the West. Radio Glasnost, a series on the West Berlin station Radio 100, started reporting on taboo subjects and opposition activities using material smuggled into West Berlin. At the same time, Roland Jahn, an earthy, blunt journalist and former opposition activist